

PQ-RNS

A hybrid post-quantum profile for the
Reticulum Network Stack (LP-9701)

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Abstract

The Reticulum Network Stack (RNS) [2, 1] is a cryptography-based mesh-networking stack designed by Mark Qvist for LoRa, packet radio, KISS modems, serial lines, free-space optical links, and any other half-duplex carrier with at least 5 bps and a 500-byte MTU. RNS provides initiator-anonymous, coordination-less, multi-hop transport with end-to-end encryption and unforgeable delivery acknowledgements, completely without IP. Its native cryptographic suite is classical: 256-bit Curve25519 keysets (X25519 for ECDH, Ed25519 for signatures), AES-256-CBC + HMAC-SHA-256 in a Fernet-style token format, SHA-256 and SHA-512 for hashing, and HKDF for key derivation. That suite is well-engineered and well-implemented, but Curve25519 is broken by a sufficiently large quantum computer: a passive recorder today can decrypt every session retrospectively when one becomes available. **PQ-RNS** is the Lux profile (LP-9701 [9]) that adds a hybrid post-quantum layer on top of classical RNS without forking the protocol: classical RNS identity (Ed25519 + X25519) remains the on-the-wire baseline; ML-KEM-768 (FIPS 203 [4]) and ML-DSA-65 (FIPS 204 [5]) extensions ride alongside in capability-negotiated announce frames. Sessions derive their AES-256 key from HKDF(X25519 shared || ML-KEM shared) so retrospective decryption requires breaking both legs. This profile is the transport that PQSAFE-IL5-HYBRID-v1 envelopes ride when IP is unavailable: contested electromagnetic environments, disaster-recovery, off-grid mesh, LoRa, and amateur-radio packet networks.

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1 Why RNS

Most post-quantum work assumes a TCP/IP carrier. RNS is the answer when the carrier itself is contested:

- **No IP needed.** RNS runs on any half-duplex medium with ≥ 5 bps and an MTU of ≥ 500 bytes. Wired Ethernet, WiFi, TCP/UDP, serial, KISS, AX.25, RNode LoRa, free-space optical, and custom modems are all first-class carriers.
- **Coordination-less globally unique addressing.** A node's address *is* the hash of its long-term Curve25519 identity – no DNS, no DHCP, no IANA. Two nodes that have never seen each other before still can address each other.
- **Initiator anonymity.** RNS packets carry no source address. The recipient knows who can decrypt; the network doesn't learn who sent.
- **Self-configuring multi-hop transport.** The protocol picks paths through any mixture of mediums automatically. A laptop on WiFi can reach a sensor on LoRa via a Raspberry Pi gateway with no operator configuration.
- **Resilient on intermittent / hostile networks.** Single-byte amplification attacks and packet-loss-induced amplification (TCP's pathologies) don't apply; RNS is designed for high packet loss.
- **Low cost of keeping links open.** A maintained RNS link costs roughly 0.44 bits/second of overhead. A full encrypted + authenticated link setup costs 297 bytes across 3 packets.

These properties make RNS the right transport for off-grid mesh, disaster recovery, contested EW environments, and IL5/CUI traffic over media that don't support TLS at all. Lux uses RNS as a peer of TCP/IP for validator-to-validator gossip in degraded conditions and as the underlay for PQSAFE envelopes when those envelopes are exchanged out-of-band of the broader internet.

1.1 Authoritative RNS reference

The Python reference implementation [1] is the authoritative protocol definition. The maintainer’s identity hash is `bc7291552be7a58f361522990465165c`. A protocol implementation is Reticulum if and only if it interoperates with that reference. The Lux PQ profile is a strict layer atop the reference: capability extension, not a fork.

2 Native RNS cryptographic suite (baseline)

The native RNS suite, taken verbatim from the reference manual and reference implementation, is:

Component	Native primitive (classical)
Identity (signing)	Ed25519 (256 bits)
Identity (KEX)	X25519 (256 bits)
Session encryption	AES-256-CBC + PKCS7 padding
Authenticated tag	HMAC-SHA-256
KDF	HKDF-SHA-256
IVs	16 bytes from <code>os.urandom()</code>
Hash	SHA-256, SHA-512
Token format	Fernet-style (no version / timestamp metadata)

Table 1: Native RNS primitives. Source: `markqvist/Reticulum Cryptographic Primitives` section.

This suite is secure against classical adversaries to roughly the 128-bit level (limited by the curve), with AEAD-equivalent integrity through the Encrypt-then-MAC composition. It is *not* post-quantum: Curve25519 falls to Shor’s algorithm.

2.1 Forward secrecy in native RNS

Native RNS already provides per-link forward secrecy: every link establishment runs a fresh X25519 ECDH between ephemeral keys, and the derived AES-256-CBC + HMAC-SHA-256 keys are scoped to that link. A compromise of either side’s long-term Curve25519 identity does not permit retrospective decryption of recorded link traffic, because the ephemeral half is gone.

PQ-RNS preserves this property and extends it to the quantum adversary.

3 PQ-RNS: the Lux profile

3.1 Goals

1. **Quantum-safe confidentiality** for every PQ-RNS link, even against a passive recorder with a future CRQC.
2. **Quantum-safe authenticity** for every PQ-RNS identity.
3. **Backward compatibility** with native RNS: mixed networks (PQ-capable and classical-only peers) coexist; PQ-required nodes cleanly refuse classical-only counterparties without breaking the rest of the mesh.
4. **Zero protocol fork.** PQ-RNS rides as a capability extension; the reference RNS implementation is the source of truth.
5. **Bandwidth-conscious.** Mesh and LoRa carriers measure in bits per second. The PQ extension must amortise its handshake cost across many sessions; per-packet overhead should not grow.

3.2 Cryptographic stack

Purpose	Native RNS (classical)	PQ-RNS extension (hybrid)
Identity signing	Ed25519	Ed25519 + ML-DSA-65 (FIPS 204)
Key exchange	X25519	X25519 + ML-KEM-768 (FIPS 203)
Session encryption	AES-256-CBC + HMAC-SHA-256	AES-256-CBC + HMAC-SHA-256 (unchanged)
Key derivation	HKDF-SHA-256	HKDF-SHA-256 over hybrid secret
Long-term identity	64-byte (Ed25519 X25519)	~3.2 KiB (Ed25519 X25519 ML-DSA-65 ML-KEM-768)

Table 2: PQ-RNS hybrid stack vs. native RNS.

The session encryption and integrity stay AES-256-CBC + HMAC-SHA-256 verbatim. AES-256 retains 128-bit effective security against Grover; HMAC-SHA-256 retains comparable strength. The hybrid extension lives at the identity and key-exchange layers, where the classical primitives fail to a CRQC.

3.3 Identity layout

A PQ-RNS identity is a sequence of four key blobs:

Listing 1: Hybrid identity wire layout.

```

1 PQ-RNS Identity ::= {
2   type:          u16 = 0x0002           // 0x0001 = classical, 0x0002 = hybrid
3   ed25519_pub:   [u8; 32]
4   x25519_pub:    [u8; 32]
5   mldsa65_pub:   [u8; 1952]           // FIPS 204 ML-DSA-65 pubkey
6   mlkem768_pub:  [u8; 1184]          // FIPS 203 ML-KEM-768 pubkey
7   fingerprint:   [u8; 16]           // SHA-256 truncated, same as native
8 }
```

The native 16-byte fingerprint is preserved – it is computed over the *whole* identity blob (including the PQ keys), so a hybrid node’s address is stable, globally unique, and observably distinct from a classical-identity hash.

3.4 Hybrid link establishment

Native RNS establishes an encrypted link in three packets totalling 297 bytes. PQ-RNS keeps the 3-packet shape; sizes grow.

Listing 2: Hybrid link-establishment packets.

```

1 LinkRequest ::= {
2   initiator_id_hash: [u8; 16]
3   initiator_eph_x25519: [u8; 32]
4   initiator_eph_mlkem768_ct: [u8; 1088] // ct to responder’s static MLKEM
5   hybrid_capability_flags: u16
6   ed25519_sig(over above): [u8; 64]
7   mldsa65_sig(over above): [u8; 3309]
8 } // ~4.5 KiB
9
10 LinkAccept ::= {
11   responder_eph_x25519: [u8; 32]
12   responder_eph_mlkem768_ct: [u8; 1088] // ct to initiator’s eph MLKEM
13   responder_ack_hmac: [u8; 32] // HMAC over derived key
14   ed25519_sig: [u8; 64]
15   mldsa65_sig: [u8; 3309]
16 } // ~4.5 KiB
17
18 LinkActivate ::= {
```

```

19 | initiator_ack_hmac: [u8; 32]
20 | -- no signatures: the link is already authenticated
21 | } // 32 bytes

```

The derived session key is

$$K_{\text{link}} = \text{HKDF-SHA-256}(\text{X25519}_{\text{eph-eph}} \parallel \text{ML-KEM-768}_{\text{eph-eph}}, \text{info} = H(\text{transcript}))$$

where the transcript is the concatenation of all three packet payloads up to the AEAD layer. The HKDF info-string binding makes the key context-locked: a replay of LinkRequest with a different LinkAccept derives a different key, so an attacker cannot graft halves of two sessions together.

3.5 Ephemeral keys, perfect forward secrecy

Both halves of the KEM are ephemeral:

- Each peer generates a fresh X25519 keypair and a fresh ML-KEM-768 keypair per link.
- The two ephemeral private keys are zeroed once K_{link} is derived.
- A future compromise of either long-term key (Ed25519 or ML-DSA-65) lets the adversary impersonate the identity going forward, but cannot decrypt recorded link traffic.
- Retrospective decryption requires breaking *both* ephemeral keys – one classical, one lattice – for every recorded link. This is the hybrid PFS contract.

3.6 AEAD over PQ-RNS

Native RNS uses Encrypt-then-MAC: AES-256-CBC + HMAC-SHA-256 in a Fernet-style token. PQ-RNS keeps this exact construction. We do not switch to AES-GCM because the native Fernet framing is part of the on-wire RNS protocol; replacing it would break interoperability with the reference implementation. The integrity tag length, padding, and sequencing are unchanged. The only difference is the key material: K_{link} derives from the hybrid secret, not the classical-only X25519 secret.

If a future RNS revision adopts a true AEAD (e.g., AES-GCM with sequence-numbered nonces, or ChaCha20-Poly1305), the PQ profile inherits that change immediately – the PQ extension affects the key derivation only, not the AEAD construction.

4 Wire-format growth

The cost of going from native RNS to PQ-RNS is approximately one order of magnitude in handshake bytes. Steady-state link cost is unchanged.

Component	Classical	Hybrid	Δ
Public identity	64 B	~3.2 KiB	+3.1 KiB
Signature (one)	64 B	~2.5 KiB	+2.4 KiB
Key exchange ct (one)	32 B	~1.2 KiB	+1.1 KiB
LinkRequest packet	~96 B	~4.5 KiB	+4.4 KiB
LinkAccept packet	~64 B	~4.5 KiB	+4.4 KiB
LinkActivate packet	32 B	32 B	0 B
Total handshake	~192 B (3 pkts)	~9 KiB (3 pkts)	+8.8 KiB
Steady-state per-packet overhead	0.44 bps	0.44 bps	0

Table 3: Wire-format growth from native RNS to PQ-RNS.

4.1 Bandwidth implications

- **Ethernet / WiFi / TCP-over-IP.** 9 KiB handshake at 100 Mbps takes 0.7 ms. Irrelevant.
- **KISS / serial 9600 baud.** 9 KiB takes ~ 7.5 s. Tolerable for one-off link setup; amortised across many requests on the link.
- **LoRa @ SF7BW125 (5470 bps usable).** 9 KiB takes ~ 14 s of channel time. Acceptable for a one-shot file drop; for streaming workloads, use a smaller hybrid (X25519-only or ML-KEM-only) or move to a faster medium for the handshake and re-engage on the link.
- **LoRa @ SF12BW125 (250 bps).** 9 KiB takes ~ 5 minutes. PQ-RNS in this regime is for low-rate command & control only; consider a pre-shared key (PSK) hybrid mode where the long-term identity is exchanged out-of-band and only ephemeral KEMs ride on the channel.
- **Free-space optical / packet-radio 1200 baud.** ~ 60 s. Practical for low-frequency link refresh.

4.2 PSK-hybrid mode for low-bandwidth carriers

For sub-1 Kbps carriers, PQ-RNS offers a PSK-hybrid mode:

- Long-term ML-KEM-768 public keys are exchanged out-of-band (e.g., over IP at provisioning, or via QR codes / signed attestations).
- Link establishment uses ephemeral X25519 + a per-link ML-KEM-768 encapsulation to the pre-shared long-term key (not a fresh ephemeral key on the responder side).
- LinkRequest/LinkAccept drop to ~ 1.3 KiB each (~ 2.6 KiB total handshake).
- This trades responder-side ephemeral PFS on the lattice leg for a $3\times$ bandwidth reduction. The X25519 leg still provides ephemeral PFS classically; the lattice leg still provides retrospective-decryption resistance.

This mode is opt-in via a capability flag (`HYBRID_PSK_RESPONDER`) and is disabled by default. It is appropriate for low-rate command links where the operator has already vetted the responder's identity through a stronger channel.

5 Capability negotiation

Native RNS `announce` frames already carry an opaque `app_data` field used by applications to advertise their capabilities. PQ-RNS rides in `app_data` with a registered namespace:

Listing 3: `app_data` PQ-RNS capability block.

```
1 {  
2   "pqrrns": {  
3     "v": 1,  
4     "profile": "PQ-RNS-HYBRID-v1",  
5     "kem": ["x25519", "mlkem768"],  
6     "sig": ["ed25519", "mldsa65"],  
7     "modes": ["hybrid_full", "hybrid_psk"],  
8     "require": false  
9   }  
10 }
```

- `require: true` – this peer refuses classical-only counterparties. Useful for strict-PQ enclaves.
- `require: false` – this peer can speak either profile. The default for mixed networks.

When two PQ-capable peers establish a link, both advertise `pqrrns` blocks. The initiator decides to use hybrid based on its own `require` flag and the responder's advertised capabilities. A peer with `require: true` that encounters a classical-only peer simply refuses to link with it (the announce frame makes this visible before any session bytes are exchanged).

6 Implementation in Lux

The Lux PQ-RNS profile is implemented in `luxfi/node` under `network/dialer/`:

File	Role
<code>rns_transport.go</code>	RNS transport adapter; exposes <code>net.Conn</code> -like surface to upstream consumers (peer.Start, ZAP RPC).
<code>rns_identity.go</code>	Classical RNS identity (Ed25519 + X25519).
<code>rns_identity_pq.go</code>	Hybrid PQ identity (adds ML-DSA-65 + ML-KEM-768).
<code>rns_link.go</code>	Encrypted link protocol with PQ support; capability-aware dispatch.
<code>rns_announce.go</code>	Destination discovery + capability advertisement.

Table 4: PQ-RNS files in `luxfi/node`.

6.1 Configuration

Listing 4: `luxfi/node` RNS configuration.

```

1 # ~/.lux/config.yaml
2 rns:
3   enabled: true
4   configPath: ~/.lux/reticulum
5   announceInterval: 5m
6   interfaces:
7     - AutoInterface           # WiFi / Ethernet auto-discovery
8     - TCPClientInterface      # explicit TCP carrier
9   linkTimeout: 30s
10  postQuantum: true           # advertise PQ capability, hybrid mode
11  requirePostQuantum: false   # accept classical peers (default)

```

Setting `requirePostQuantum: true` in a deployment makes that node a strict-PQ enclave; classical-only peers cannot link, and any attempt is rejected before key material is exchanged.

6.2 Composition with Z-Wing and PQSAFE

PQ-RNS, Z-Wing (`luxfi/zwing` [10]), and PQSAFE-IL5-HYBRID-v1 (`luxfi/papers/pqsafe-il5` [11]) compose orthogonally:

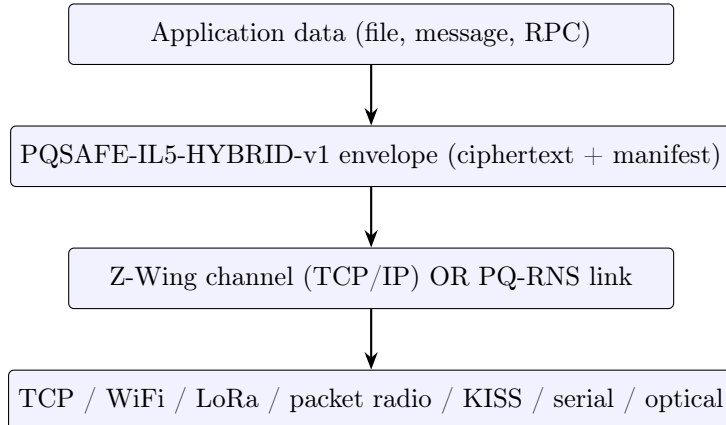


Figure 1: Composition stack. PQSAFE envelope rides over either Z-Wing (TCP/IP) or PQ-RNS (mesh / LoRa / packet radio). The carrier layer is chosen at runtime; the envelope is identical.

- **PQSAFE** is the application-layer envelope. Every byte that leaves the sender is encrypted, signed, manifest-bound, and audit-anchored.

- **Z-Wing** is the secure channel over TCP/IP. Provides endpoint authentication, replay protection, and hybrid PQ confidentiality.
- **PQ-RNS** is the secure channel over non-IP carriers. Same role as Z-Wing but for mesh, LoRa, packet radio, etc.
- The choice between Z-Wing and PQ-RNS is made by the application; the PQSAFE envelope doesn't care which carrier it rides.

7 Use cases

7.1 Disaster recovery / off-grid mesh

After an event that knocks out IP infrastructure (storm, cyberattack, EMP), PQ-RNS over LoRa lets agencies continue to exchange CUI files encrypted with PQSAFE. The PQ leg ensures that even a passive recorder operating during the outage cannot retrospectively decrypt the exchanged files when IP comes back online and the recordings can be processed with future CRQCs.

7.2 Contested EW environments

In a contested electromagnetic environment, RNS's medium-agility (LoRa, packet radio, optical, custom modems) makes it harder for an adversary to deny service across all carriers simultaneously. The PQ layer ensures that even traffic captured during the contest is post-quantum secure.

7.3 Validator gossip on degraded networks

Lux primary-network validators that lose IP connectivity but retain a LoRa or packet-radio backhaul to other validators continue to gossip consensus messages via PQ-RNS. The QuasarCert wire format is unchanged; the carrier moves underneath.

7.4 Cross-agency air-gap bridges

An air-gap can be bridged with a directional optical link or a dedicated LoRa hop. PQ-RNS rides that hop with PQ confidentiality; the air-gap policy enforces classification at the endpoint, not at the wire.

7.5 Out-of-band identity provisioning

For PSK-hybrid mode (Section 3), long-term ML-KEM-768 public keys are exchanged through QR codes, signed PDFs, or a trusted IP rendezvous. The PQ-RNS link then bootstraps with no plaintext identity exchange over the constrained carrier.

8 Migration and compatibility

8.1 Mixed networks

Native RNS and PQ-RNS coexist transparently. A PQ-capable node advertises both classical and hybrid capabilities in its announce frame. Classical-only nodes ignore the `pqrns` block and engage classical link establishment; PQ-capable nodes detect each other and upgrade to hybrid.

A `require: true` node refuses classical-only peers entirely, which is what strict-PQ enclaves want: a misconfigured classical-only peer in a strict-PQ enclave fails to link with any local peer rather than silently falling back to classical.

8.2 Migration to pure-PQ RNS

Pure-PQ RNS is the explicit exit ramp:

1. **PQ-RNS-HYBRID-v1** (this profile): X25519 + ML-KEM-768, Ed25519 + ML-DSA-65. Production today.
2. **PQ-RNS-HYBRID-v2**: X448 + ML-KEM-1024, Ed448 + ML-DSA-87. High-assurance variant; same shape, larger parameters.
3. **PQ-RNS-PURE-PQ-v1**: ML-KEM-768/1024 only, ML-DSA-65/87 only (no X25519/X448, no Ed25519/Ed448). Activated when CNSA 3.0 (or equivalent) policy permits classical-curve removal in mesh deployments.

Mixed-version operation is supported as long as both peers agree on a version they both implement. The reference RNS implementation is not expected to add PQ natively; the Lux PQ-RNS profile is the interoperable extension.

9 What we don't do

- Don't fork the RNS reference implementation.
- Don't replace AES-256-CBC + HMAC-SHA-256 with a new AEAD unless the reference implementation does so first (preserves interoperability).
- Don't add cipher-suite negotiation inside a profile. New capabilities are new profile versions, not parameters within a profile.
- Don't claim PQ-RNS is "RNS" in protocol-conformance language. It is a Lux extension; the reference RNS implementation is the authoritative protocol definition. PQ-RNS is interoperable with native RNS by design; non-PQ nodes see PQ nodes as ordinary RNS peers.
- Don't run pure-PQ RNS before the migration window closes. Lattice-only mode loses the X25519 fallback if a future lattice-specific attack appears.

10 Conclusion

PQ-RNS is the post-quantum extension that lets Reticulum's mesh-networking philosophy carry forward into the CRQC era without losing what makes RNS uniquely useful: zero coordination, initiator anonymity, half-duplex carriers, and operation on any wire from 5 bps to 1 Gbps. The cost is one-off: a 9 KiB handshake per link, amortised across the lifetime of that link. The benefit is permanent: retrospective decryption of recorded sessions requires breaking both the X25519 ephemeral half and the ML-KEM-768 ephemeral half of the hybrid key exchange, and the long-term identity continues to verify under both Ed25519 and ML-DSA-65.

Paired with Z-Wing for TCP/IP and PQSAFE for envelope encryption, PQ-RNS completes the Lux end-to-end post-quantum stack: *every byte that leaves a Lux endpoint can be encrypted with NIST-standardised hybrid primitives no matter what carries it.*

References

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